

Ryan Cosner: Personal History Statement

Alongside my technical focus on Mechanical Engineering and Controls, I have also strived to gain a breadth of experiences in other fields. I raced triathlons, played trombone in the UC Berkeley marching band, took courses on relativistic physics and American history, and attained intermediate fluency in Spanish. I did all of that and more in order to broaden my perspective and expand my knowledge. Those experiences, along with my personal background, have been formative and strongly influenced my decision to pursue a graduate degree and a career as a university professor.

In terms of my personal background, my mixed-culture and racial heritage have allowed me to define my identity in unique ways. My father's German-Irish family has a strong proclivity for engineering, but otherwise has generally American traditions. Meanwhile, my mother's Japanese family was forced to reject much of their culture due to the internment camps and anti-Japanese fervor present during World War 2. Growing up, I did not have strong cultural traditions and was often erroneously identified as Central or South American based on my appearance. To many, I am not truly Japanese because I lack culture, not truly white because I have a mixed racial heritage, and, despite my appearance, not truly Latino. As a child, I felt rejected by common cultural identities, so I developed my own. I have learned to define myself by my diverse set of interests, my passion for engineering, and my ideological beliefs. I am not the color of my skin nor the language that I speak, but rather I am defined by my commitment to education, my fascination with physical systems, the value that I place on my relationships with others, and my own personal experiences. Developing my unique identity has made me open-minded and uniquely capable of teamwork and communication across cultures. It has taught me to value diversity and made me a very welcoming and sympathetic person.

Beyond that cultural understanding, my extracurricular experiences have inspired me to pursue a career as an educator. As a volunteer teacher in Peru, I realized the vast untapped potential that exists in students across the globe. I worked in the semi-rural town of Chinchá teaching basic engineering design, circuitry, and computer coding in both English and Spanish to high school

students. As I taught, I saw my students develop passions for STEM fields and dream of careers which had previously felt out of reach. I realized that they had the innate ability to achieve those goals and simply needed a teacher like myself to believe in and support them. Since then, I have improved my Spanish language skills through coursework and have continued serving underrepresented communities, like the Latin-American community, by inspiring and supporting students to pursue higher education and careers in STEM. In specific, I have served those communities through my work as a Campus Ambassador for UC Berkeley. In that job, I have had the privilege of being the tour guide for groups of diverse and often underprivileged middle and high school students. It is very common for those groups to be intimidated by prestigious universities like UC Berkeley and of the college application process in general, believing that college is for someone of a different social standing or racial group. Therefore, during my tours, I do everything that I can to make a college degree feel attainable for everyone and to inspire my tour group to pursue higher education. Although I cannot know the exact impacts of my work, I hope that I have been able to change people's lives by helping them envision a path to higher education and emboldening them to pursue it.

Generally, I believe that educators have the incredible opportunity to lend their support to others and to inspire them to be more than they thought they could be. My personal background and extracurricular experiences have shown me the artificial nature of racial and cultural walls and have demonstrated the profound impact that I can have through outreach and as an educator. Because of that, I have committed myself to teaching and supporting students of all backgrounds and I eagerly look forward to pursuing that commitment in graduate school and in my future career.